

Populism and Counterterrorism Preferences: The Roles of Strongman Rule, Outgroup Attitudes, and Conspiratorial Thinking in Shaping Policy Support

Abstract: What kinds of counterterrorism policies do populist individuals in the United States prefer in the aftermath of terrorist attacks? We theorize that these preferences are shaped by attitudes toward liberal institutions, social outgroups, and conspiratorial beliefs. To test this, we conducted an original survey of 1,940 subjects living in the United States. We found that subjects exhibiting populist attitudes were more likely to support unilateral, militarized counterterrorism policies in response to terrorist attacks but were less supportive of cooperative, or multilateral counterterrorism policies. We also found greater support among these individuals for restrictive domestic security measures, including immigration and border controls, and expanded government authority related to surveillance, detention, and arrest. To understand more about these patterns, we also conducted mediation tests and found that support for strongman rule, perceived threats from outgroups, and conspiratorial thinking patterns are strong and substantive mediators for the relationship between populism and counterterrorism preferences.

What sorts of counterterrorism responses do Americans with populist attitudes¹ prefer in the wake of terrorist attacks? Several points motivate this question. First, populism as a political phenomenon has grown both in the United States and world-wide and is currently the most prominent political current today (Norris 2020). Second, references to terrorism feature prominently in the rhetoric of many populist political actors (Liang 2007), who often frame terrorism as a fundamental threat to national security and societal stability (Hall 2020). Prior research has shown that terrorist attacks can increase electoral support for populist parties, particularly among individuals with right-wing predispositions (Jacobs and van Spanje 2021). More broadly, scholars argue that the appeal of populism is, in part, reinforced by perceptions of threat and insecurity (Abadi et al. 2024), with Van Prooijen (2023) theorizing that support for populist politicians is a psychological coping mechanism for citizens experiencing anxiety in response to such perceived threats.

While much of the scholarly research on populism focuses on domestic politics and policy (Verbeek and Zaslove 2017), there is a burgeoning literature on the ramifications of populism for foreign policy, including international security policy (see, for example, Cadier et al. 2025; Chrysosgelos 2017; Destradi et al. 2021; Löfflmann 2022; Wajner et al. 2024). Current research on populism and foreign policy, however, concentrates on the foreign policies pursued by populist political leaders and governments, populist leader rhetoric on foreign policy, and the implications of populist leadership on states' policies toward multilateral cooperation. This literature uncovers critical implications of populist governance on international security policies pursued by states while challenges some preexisting notions about populist rule (see Eiran et al.

¹ Our study investigates the attitudes and preferences of U.S. survey subjects who hold pro-populist beliefs and values. It therefore focuses on what is sometimes called the “demand side” of populism (see Marcos-Marne et al. 2023), while much of the other literature focuses on populist leaders, populist regimes, and the “supply side” of populism. In the study, when we refer to populists, we mean individuals holding populist views.

2025). However, the current literature on populism and foreign policy does not investigate the implications of populist attitudes among citizens and how they shape international security policy preferences, such as counterterrorism policies.

We complement the literature on populist leaders and international security policy by studying how individuals in the United States that hold populist preferences respond to the threat of terrorism along with the specific counterterrorism and security policies they prefer—both domestically and internationally – in the wake of a terrorist attack. We contribute to the demand side literature on populism by examining how terrorist threats shape populist individuals’ preferences both for domestic counterterrorism policies associated with border control, immigration, and internal security as well as foreign counterterrorism policies such as the use of military force to address terrorism, provision of aid to allies, and promotion of democracy overseas.

We also explore the link between populist attitudes and support for various types of responses to terrorism by investigating the roles played by preferences for concentrated executive power and strong leadership, perceived outgroup threat, and conspiratorial thinking patterns; all of which are identified in the literature as associated with populist sentiment. This contribution helps to join the demand-side literature on populism with the burgeoning research on populism and national and foreign security policy. Moreover, our study helps to identify whether populist attitudes in themselves are driving counterterrorism preferences in the aftermath or rather if populism functions as an epiphenomenon in driving elements such as authoritarianism, or conspiratorialism that reinforce individuals’ reactions to terrorist attacks. In the next section of the paper, we provide a brief definition of populism. We then present our main theoretical arguments and discuss the literatures that support these arguments. We follow

our theory section with a presentation of our hypotheses and then present our research design and empirical results. Finally, we provide a brief discussion of the implications and limitations of our study.

What is Populism?

Before presenting our theoretical arguments, we provide a brief conceptual definition of populism and how we apply it in our study. Populism is a contested concept (see Roccato et al. 2020), but most scholars regard it as a loose ideological framework that includes the following tenets: Populists argue that contemporary society is divided into two differentiated political-social-cultural forces. On one side is “the people” who are depicted as good, honest, moral, and representative of common sense. On the other side are “the elites” who are viewed as dishonest, corrupt, unpatriotic, pretentious, and often lacking in commonsensical judgement (Akkerman, Mudde, Zaslove 2014).

Populist narratives therefore tend to interpret politics, society, and culture through a Manichean lens in which “the people” are seen as having the legitimate authority to govern but are obstructed by “the elites” who are perceived to undermine their interests (Hawkins, Ridding, and Mudde 2012). Furthermore, scholars argue that these features—Manichean view of politics, reverence for the people, and distrust of elites are reinforced by skepticism toward experts, perceived exclusion from mainstream political processes, and a tendency to interpret politics in moral rather than institutional or pluralist terms (Akkerman et al. 2014; Oliver and Rahn 2016; Castanho Silva et al. 2018).

In our study, we conceptualize populism as a set of attitudes about politics distinct from partisanship. We follow Oliver and Rahn (2016) in defining it as a moralized, anti-establishment

worldview that pits a virtuous people against a corrupt elite often through a Manichean lens that privileges common wisdom over expert knowledge. We adopt this definition because it is tailored to the U.S. context and focuses on how citizens understand and evaluate politics, which makes it well suited for our “demand-side” approach. However, some of the theoretical expectations we have about populists’ counterterrorism preferences are more consistent with right-leaning variants of populism. Our theory of American populist individuals’ preferences are consistent with Kriesi’s (2014) work showing that populist actors and publics in the United States and other Western countries often define “the people” in nativist terms, a pattern more commonly associated with populism on the political right.²

How Populism Shapes Individuals’ Counterterrorism Response Preferences

We expect populist individuals to respond to the threat of terrorism differently and to favor certain types of international and domestic counterterrorism (“CT”) policies. The precis of our theory is that terrorist attacks produce feelings of fear and vulnerability to danger among people. For populist individuals, these feelings may reinforce preexisting distrust of elites, social outgroups, and mainstream political institutions. This is expected to manifest in CT preferences for unilateral, militarized responses at the foreign policy level and expanded domestic security

² Our operationalization of populism / populist attitudes theoretically transcends partisan identity and political ideology, as shown in the nonpartisan, nonideological survey questions we use to construct our populism index. This is consistent with Mudde’s (2007) depiction of populism as a “thin-centered ideology” that can be grafted onto both left- and right-wing political movements. That said, we take several steps to address the possibility that what we really capture in our analysis is the effect of right-wing populist attitudes. First, we control for partisanship and political ideology in all of our models. Second, we calculate correlations between our populism index and all of the controls in the models (reported in the appendix). We find that while Republicans and conservatives are more likely to score higher on the populism index, African Americans and women do as well, suggesting a complex picture. Finally, we robustness check models that interact left- and right-wing political ideology with the populism index. This allows us to determine whether left- or right-wing populist individuals have unique CT responses. The results of these checks (reported in the appendix) do not show that left- and right-wing populists have unique CT preferences in the wake of an attack. Rather, the non-partisan, cross-ideological populism index bears the same relationship with CT preferences of subjects as that found in the main models.

measures. Moreover we expect that these preferences are mediated through increased support for strong centralized authority, skepticism toward outgroups, and conspiratorial beliefs. Our theoretical discussion begins by outlining the types of CT policies we consider in our study.

International CT policies that we examine include: 1) the deployment of U.S. ground troops abroad to terrorism “hotspots” to confront terrorist organizations; 2) the provision of U.S. military aid and intelligence to allied countries to bolster their security and help them neutralize terrorists; 3) U.S. promotion of democracy abroad to countries affected by terrorism in order to neutralize grievances that may fuel terrorism. These three types of international CT policies represent major strategies the United States has used in prosecuting the Global War on Terror since 2001. Taken together they also comprise unilateral use of U.S. hard power, multilateral cooperative measures, and use of soft power to combat terrorist threats to the U.S.. The three domestic CT policies we examine include: 1) increasing U.S. border security; 2) reduction of immigration to the United States to prevent the entry of terrorists into the United States; and 3) U.S. government use of arrests, detention, and surveillance of people from the same communities as terrorist suspects and offenders. These three comprise prominent domestic CT responses implemented in the U.S. in the aftermath of the 9/11 attacks.

Populism and Foreign and Domestic Security Policy Preferences

The literature on American public responses to terrorist threats suggest that individuals who perceive a high threat of future terrorism tend to favor retaliatory anti-terrorism policies both domestically and internationally, including overseas military interventions and restrictive domestic responses (Huddy et al. 2005; Huddy et al. 2007), especially when the threat is

communicated in a graphic and emotionally powerful manner by the media (Gadarian 2010; 2014).

Though scholars have not directly investigated the effect of populist attitudes on CT policy preferences, some research explores how populism shapes broader foreign policy preferences. For example, Isernia et al. (2024) explain that individuals with populist attitudes favor hard power, militarist internationalism and unilateralism. In contrast, they disdain cooperative internationalism. Populists are also less supportive of foreign policy options such as humanitarian assistance, or promoting democracy and human rights abroad. According to Isernia et al. (2024), this stems from the populist view that military force is a straightforward and uncorrupted means of addressing international security threats while multilateral institutions are viewed as compromised by elite interests.

The wider literature on the foreign policy rhetoric and orientation of populist leaders and governments displays a similar set of preferences. Populist leaders are generally opposed to multilateral military missions (Verbeek and Zaslove 2017), are skeptical of multilateral governing bodies and international institutions (Chrysosgelos 2010; Destradi et al. 2021; Eiran et al. 2025; Mead 2011; Mudde 2023; Wajner et al. 2024) seeing them as threats to national sovereignty (Zurn 2004; Amstutz 2014).³ Moreover, researchers show that populist politicians deprioritize foreign policies that promote democracy abroad (see Buzogany et al. 2021; Monkos 2021); reflecting their broader skepticism toward mainstream institutions (see, for example, Bergh 2004; Roccato et al. 2020). Taken together, these studies produce a populist foreign policy brand that we theorize informs the counterterrorism policy preferences of individuals who

³ At least philosophically or rhetorically. Destradi et al. (2021) note some skepticism that populist leaders are more likely to pursue unilateral, bellicose international security policies and eschew multilateral cooperation in fact. However, we expect that the philosophical and rhetorical investment in unilateralism by populist leaders affects populist individuals' attitudes about international security and shapes their responses to terrorism threats.

hold populist viewpoints. We suspect that such individuals are more likely to respond to the threat of terrorism by favoring unilateral military international CT policies instead of cooperative forms of CT.

A more developed body of work establishes that immigration control is a paramount domestic policy issue for populists (Ivarsflaten 2008; Mudde 2007). Mudde (2007) observes that immigration control dovetails with the nationalist ethos of populism (see Liang 2007). Scholars also note that perceived terrorism threats play a role in supporting stricter border policies among populists (Jacobs and van Spanje 2021; Altheide 2017). Experimental research further shows that populism is associated with skepticism toward outgroups (Bonikowski and Zhang 2023; Magalhaes and Costa-Lopes 2023). These findings are consistent with scholarship arguing that populists are less supportive of extending political rights to groups they do not identify with (Huber and Schimpf 2017; Mudde and Kaltwasser 2018).

The Mediating Role of Strongman Rule, Outgroup Threat, and Conspiratorial Thinking

We argue that three factors mediate the relationship between populism and CT preferences: a preference for strong, centralized leadership; distrust or suspicion toward social outgroups; and a propensity for conspiratorial attitudes. In focusing on these mediators, we are able to discern whether populist outlooks directly shape subjects' responses to terrorism threats or if rather populism works through other factors. We discuss these mediating factors in turn.

Populism, Support for Strongman Rule, and CT Preferences

Scholars have amply documented the pro-strongman preferences of both populist elites (e.g., leaders and political parties) and individuals holding populist attitudes. Due to the anti-

establishment ethos of populism, populist individuals often express skepticism toward liberal democracy, viewing it as compromised by elites and overly accommodating to groups perceived as outside the core national community (Kriesi 2014). In response, many populists advocate for a strong leader who embodies the will of the “true people” and operates with limited constraints from institutional checks and balances.

When in office, populist leaders and political parties often implement policies that emphasize majoritarianism, framing such measures as necessary to combat elite corruption (Akkerman et al. 2014; Kriesi and Pappas 2015; Mudde and Kaltwasser 2018;). Behavioral studies further find that individuals holding populist beliefs are more likely to express skepticism toward liberal norms (Donovan 2021; Lewandowsky and Jankowski 2023) and to support “strong man” leaders who promise to eliminate elite corruption through concentrated executive authority, even at the expense of institutional checks, or protections for minority groups (Piazza 2024a).

We argue that, due to their preference for strong, centralized leadership, individuals with populist views are more likely to favor unilateral military responses to terrorism and to express skepticism toward multilateral cooperation with allies or liberal CT policies, such as democracy promotion aimed at addressing deradicalization abroad. On the domestic front, this orientation is associated with support for policies such as reduced immigration, increased border security, and expanded surveillance, arrests, and detentions in the service of CT.

Although these contentions have not been directly tested, existing literature supports our expectations. Scholars have found that individuals with lower support for liberal norms are more likely to favor militarized international engagement over cooperative foreign policy frameworks (Kertzer et al. 2014). Kertzer et al. (2014) attribute this to a pattern of deference to authority—

an individual-level psychological trait associated with support for strong leadership, which is negatively associated with support for cooperative internationalism. Extant work on U.S. public responses to terrorism also supports this logic. Variation in support for the use of force to address national security threats has been linked to individual differences in authoritarian predispositions (Hetherington and Weiler 2009). Even those who do not typically exhibit these predispositions may adopt more hawkish policy preferences when exposed to terrorist threats (Hetherington and Suhay 2009).

Other studies find that individuals scoring higher on right-wing authoritarian and social dominance orientation scales prefer hawkish foreign policies and the use of military force against both state and nonstate actors over cooperative or multilateral approaches (Albuyeh and Paradis 2018; Mutz and Kim 2017; Rathbun et al. 2016). Rathbun (2020), for example, argues that right-wing authoritarianism is associated with heightened perceptions of threat, which tends to reinforce preferences for more confrontational foreign policy positions. This leads to our first hypothesis:

H1. Populist individuals are more likely to prefer unilateral deployment of military forces abroad to address terrorism threats and are less likely to prefer multilateral cooperation with allies or policies such as democracy promotion due to their preference for strongman governance.

At the same time, we expect populist orientations will reinforce subjects' support for domestic CT policies that prioritize reducing immigration, tightening border security, and expanding government authority in areas such as surveillance, detention, and arrests in response to terrorist threats. This expectation follows from prior research showing that a) individuals under terrorist threat place a greater value on strong leadership and granting increased authority to these leaders (Merolla and Zechmeister 2009) and b) individuals with populists views express skepticism

toward of mainstream institutions and legal frameworks that protect individual and minority rights (Arato and Cohen 2017; Mudde and Kaltwasser 2017; Piazza 2024). This skepticism aligns with a broader preference for strong leadership that emphasizes decisive state action over procedural constraints.

Populist movements also frequently prioritize the preservation of security and public order (Salvati et al. 2022). Accordingly, we expect greater support among individuals with populist views for (1) increased border security as a measure to prevent terrorist entry, (2) immigration restrictions aimed at reducing perceived security threats from foreign populations, and (3) the expanded use of surveillance, arrests, and detention targeting communities linked to suspected terrorists. This leads to our second hypothesis:

H2. Populist individuals are more likely to support immigration and border restrictions, and surveillance, arrest, and detention of communities linked to suspected terrorists to address terrorist threats due to their preference for strongman governance.

Populism, Perceived Outgroup Threat, and CT

As noted earlier, a core feature of the populist worldview is the belief that the people's will should guide all aspects of political decision-making. Scholars who study populism note, however, that (right-wing) populists tend to define "the people" in majoritarian terms grounded in racial, ethnic, religious, and cultural identity, and often exclude minorities or immigrants from this category (Roccato et al. 2020). This conception contributes to perceptions of threat from outgroups, as populist leaders often portray minorities and immigrants not only as culturally distinct but also as potential risks to national security and social cohesion (Berman 2021; Oliver and Rahn 2016). At the same time, populist leaders frequently challenge institutions that protect minority group rights (Akkerman et al. 2014; Kokkonen and Linde 2023).

These perceptions of outgroups have implications for public attitudes and behaviors. For instance, scholars show that individuals who hold nativist attitudes are more likely to vote for populist parties and candidates (Maier et al. 2022). Piazza (2023) determines that populist individuals respond to increasing social diversity by expressing heightened sensitivity to perceived threats to racial and ethnic status, consistent with intergroup conflict theory (see Brewer 1999). Experimental research by Martinez et al. (2022) demonstrates a link between populist attitudes and skepticism toward social outgroups. Based on this, we expect populist individuals in our study to express lower regard for racial, ethnic, and cultural minority groups and, in turn, to support CT policies that emphasize the protection of ingroup status and cohesion. This is expected to manifest in support for both U.S. military CT operations abroad and endorsement of domestic CT enforcement measures.

Several strands of literature support our expectations. Scholars have found that social ingroup identification and loyalty – as conceptualized by Brewer (1999) in her model of intergroup conflict theory – are positively associated with support for militarized international engagement, including the use of military force abroad to defend perceived members of the ingroup from domestic and international security threats, and negatively associated with cooperative internationalism (Kertzer et al. 2014; Rathbun 2020; Rathbun et al. 2016). Kam and Kinder (2007), for instance, show that ethnocentric individuals in the U.S. were most supportive of the US’s use of military force in the prosecution of the Global War on Terror.

At the same time, we argue that skepticism toward social outgroups and their claims to rights reinforces support among populist individuals for domestic CT policies that include immigration restrictions, tighter controls on cross-border movement, and expanded state authority. Terrorism is known to increase threat sensitivity. In contexts of sustained terrorist

threat, individuals often respond by seeking to restore a sense of control, which can manifest as heightened wariness of those perceived to fall outside the societal mainstream (Merolla and Zechmeister 2009). This dynamic can reduce political tolerance among individuals, who become more supportive of policies that constrain the rights of groups perceived to be associated with the sources of threat (Peffley et al. 2015; Peffley et al. 2022).

This expectation is supported by research on U.S. public opinion showing that concerns among white Americans about the perceived erosion of their sociopolitical status amid increasing immigration are a key factor in explaining support for immigration restrictions, stricter border enforcement, and the prioritization of domestic security (Mason et al. 2021). This leads to our next set of hypotheses:

H3. Populist individuals are more likely to prefer unilateral deployment of military forces abroad to address terrorism threats and are less likely to prefer multilateral cooperation with allies or policies such as democracy promotion due to perceived threats from outgroups.

H4. Populist individuals are more likely to support restrictive immigration and border policies, as well as expanded domestic security measures, such as surveillance, arrest, and detention of communities linked to suspected terrorists to address terrorist threats due to perceived threats from outgroups.

Populism, Conspiratorial Thinking, and CT

Our final mediating factor is conspiratorial belief systems or patterns of thinking. A growing body of literature demonstrates that populism is closely associated with conspiracy beliefs and that populist individuals are more likely to exhibit conspiratorial thinking (Castanho Silva et al. 2017). Conspiracies are understood by political scientists to be explanations that attribute significant political or economic events to covert actions by powerful actors aiming to subvert institutions, or conceal critical information (Douglas et al. 2019: 4). Scholars note that a core

element of populist discourse is the belief that the people's will is subverted by corrupt elites operating behind the scenes, often in collusion with unaccountable institutions or official actors (Mudde and Kaltwasser 2013).

Populist political actors have been shown to promote conspiracy theories that challenge the legitimacy of mainstream political norms and institutions in both European countries (Rydgren 2004) and in the United States (Postel 2007). Empirical studies consistently find that populist attitudes correlate with a greater propensity to endorse conspiracy theories (Castanho et al. 2017; Salvati et al. 2022; Uscinski et al. 2022; van Prooijen et al. 2022b). In that sense, conspiratorial thinking functions as a cognitive framework through which populist individuals interpret political and security threats.

We do not expect conspiratorial thinking to have a discernible impact on preferences for international CT policies. To our knowledge, existing empirical research does not indicate that individuals with conspiratorial worldviews are more likely to support hawkish, cooperative, or liberal foreign security policies. However, we do expect that populists who hold conspiratorial beliefs are more likely to prefer CT policies directed at perceived internal threats, including immigration restrictions and expanded state powers.

A growing body of research links conspiratorial thinking with reduced support for liberal democratic rights and increased suspicion toward outgroups. Van Prooijen (2024) demonstrates that conspiracy theories shape group responses to perceived threats by amplifying perceptions that outgroups are dangerous, while simultaneously fostering ingroup cohesion and a motivation to defend perceived ingroup interests. We suggest that one policy-relevant manifestation of this dynamic is increased support for restrictive immigrant and border enforcement measures, along

with expanded surveillance, arrest, and detention powers, particularly when these are viewed to target groups associated with the perceived national or social threats.

At the same time, populist variants of conspiratorial thinking often portray political and security threats as the result of deliberate actions by corrupt elites who are framed as undermining national security. Van Prooijen and Douglas (2018) argue that this democratic skepticism is rooted in feelings of powerlessness in the face of perceived threats, which conspiracy theories help to explain by attributing blame to identifiable outgroups. This helps explain support among populist individuals for CT policies that place less emphasis on pluralist protections. If democracy itself is viewed as compromised—controlled by unaccountable elites—then suspending liberal norms in the name of national security may appear not only defensible but necessary. Under these conditions, liberal democratic guarantees may be viewed as enabling threats, thus creating support for domestic counterterrorism policies that emphasize coercive state action and heightened scrutiny of groups perceived as connected to those threats. This leads to our final hypothesis:

H5. Populist individuals are more likely to support restrictive immigration and border policies, as well as expanded domestic security measures, such as surveillance, arrest, and detention of communities linked to suspected terrorists to address terrorist threats due to conspiratorial thinking patterns.

Research Design

We test our hypotheses using original survey data of 1,940 individuals living in the United States.⁴ The survey was conducted on Lucid Theorem and was fielded between January 17 and

⁴ While the United States shares some contextual similarity with other countries – it is facing a populist moment in its politics, immigration is a highly salient political topic, and conspiratorial thinking has become a prominent factor in national political life – it also has some features that make it more unique. The U.S. has experienced large, transnational terrorist attacks that have had a profound effect on politics and society, has a greater counterterrorism capacity due to its military hegemonic status, and has a robust recent legacy of engaging in militarized and soft and unilateral and multilateral counterterrorism projects embodied in the Global War on Terror. We therefore do not

February 7, 2023. The Lucid online panel is representative of the U.S. adult population (Coppock and McClellan 2019) and has been utilized in numerous recent studies on U.S. public opinion, including those that examine support for retaliation and more authoritarian forms of rule amidst terrorist threats (Caton and Mullinix 2023; Piazza 2023; Wayne 2023).

Prior to measuring respondents' counterterrorism preferences, we presented them with a stimulus in the form of a fictional news report of a terrorist attack. We slightly varied, at random, attribution, claiming, and denial of responsibility for the purported terrorist attack to hold constant the effect that the name of the perpetrator had on subjects' responses.⁵ We included this stimulus to increase the salience and realism of the issue for all respondents (Druckman 2022).⁶ After completing the survey, participants were debriefed and informed that the news story they had read before the survey was entirely fictional. Throughout the survey, multiple attention tests were used to address concerns over subject inattentiveness⁷. The median respondent took 13.6 minutes to complete the survey. The full survey instrument is published in the appendix along with descriptive, scalability, and distribution statistics for all variables used in the study.

claim that our findings are necessarily reproducible in other national contexts. Future research might explore how similar dynamics manifest in Europe (where multilateralism constrains unilateral action), Latin America (where populism targets domestic crime more than transnational terrorism), the Middle East (where regime-led populism and securitization intersect), and South Asia (where populist nationalism fuses with majoritarian identity politics).

⁵ As a robustness check, we reran our analyses while controlling for these different conditions and found that they do not change the main results. These robustness checks along with the full text of the vignettes are included in the appendix.

⁶ Please see the appendix for a discussion of the effects of issue salience on experimental subjects.

⁷ Consistent with recommendations in the literature (Berinsky et al. 2014), we recognize the value of comparing models that include and exclude respondents who fail attention checks. In our case, however, respondents who failed the attention checks were removed from the survey, and their data were therefore not retained. While this limits our ability to assess potential differences, we note that our sample includes respondents with varying levels of engagement reflected by how long they spent completing the survey, and we account for this variation in our models.

Dependent Variables

To measure respondents' counterterrorism preferences, we employ six dependent variables—three addressing preferences for militarized or cooperative approaches in *international counterterrorism responses* and three focusing on domestic security measures in *domestic counterterrorism responses*. In the former category, *international counterterrorism responses*, we measure respondent support for (1) deploying ground troops to countries where terrorists are based to apprehend suspects, (2) providing military aid and intelligence to governments of those countries to assist in combating terrorism, and (3) promoting democracy, human rights, and civil liberties in those countries as a means of addressing terrorism at its source. In the latter category, *domestic counterterrorism responses*, we measure support for (4) increasing border security in the U.S., (5) reducing immigration to the U.S., and (6) arresting, detaining, or increasing surveillance of domestic communities perceived as potential supporters of terrorism.

All six measures are based on responses to questions with four answer choices—*strongly disagree*, *somewhat disagree*, *somewhat agree*, and *strongly agree*⁸—and are treated as ordinal variables ranging from 1 (indicating the lowest level of support for the specified counterterrorism response) to 4 (indicating the highest level of support). Overall, support for different international and domestic counterterrorism responses among respondents exhibits varied trends. This is illustrated by Figure 1. For instance, respondents show stronger support for cooperative international counterterrorism strategies (like providing aid to foreign countries to assist in combating terrorism) than direct military intervention (deploying ground troops abroad). As for

⁸ To prevent “midpoint response bias”, we did not include a middle category on our response scale. Respondents may select the middle category to reduce cognitive effort (Morii et al., 2017) or as a result of satisficing (Krosnick, 1991).

domestic responses, respondents tend to favor border security measures but show mixed views on immigration restrictions and surveillance.

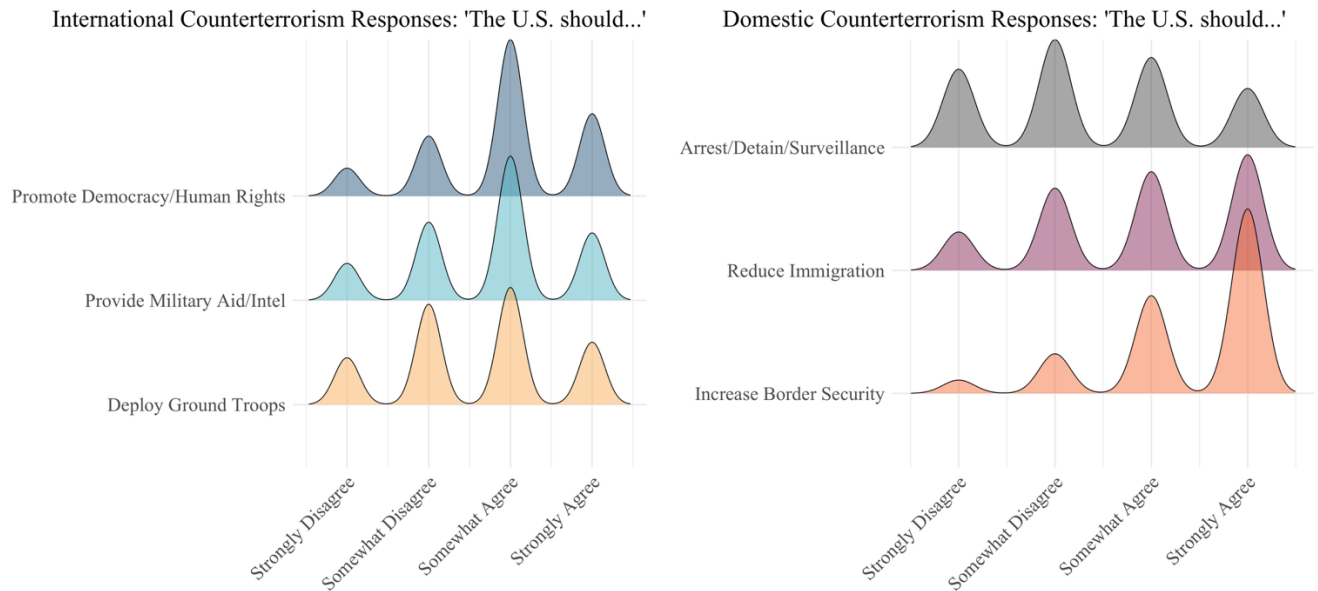


Figure 1. Distribution of Preferences for Counterterrorism Responses by Policy Type

Independent Variable

Our main independent variable measures respondents' populist attitudes. For our study we used eight questions that were developed by Oliver and Rahn (2016), specifically for the study of populist attitudes in the U.S and have been used by previous studies on how populist attitudes influence U.S. public opinion about a variety of contentious issues (Armaly and Enders 2024a; Armaly and Ender 2024b; Piazza 2024). We presented all eight questions with four answer choices—*strongly disagree*, *somewhat disagree*, *somewhat agree*, and *strongly agree*. We construct a mean-scaled unweighted additive index of populist attitudes by summing responses to these eight survey. The resulting populist attitudes index is continuous and ranges from 1, indicating an absence of populist attitudes, and to 4, indicating the highest level of populist sentiments.

The mean and median scores on the populism index for respondents are 2.74 and 2.75, respectively, suggesting a normal distribution of populist attitudes across the sample. This is illustrated in Figure 2.

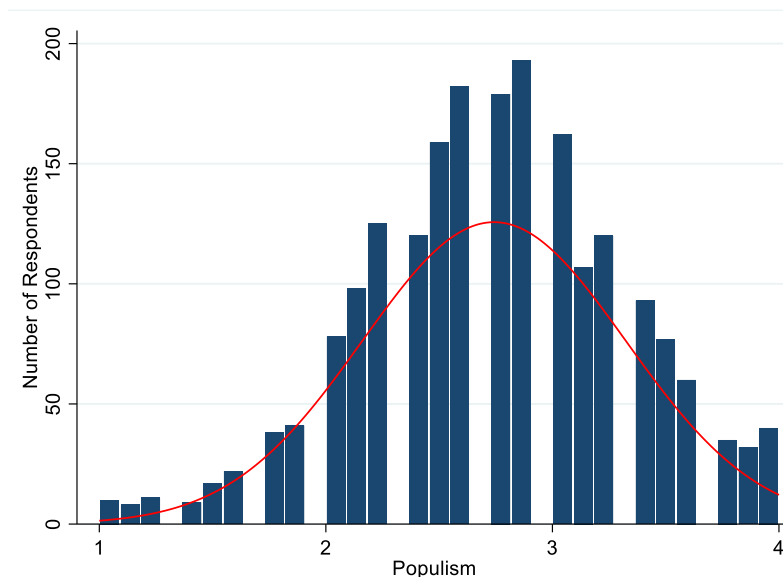


Figure 2. Histogram of Populism Scores with Density Estimate

Mediators

We employ three mediators to test our hypotheses: support for “strongman” rule, distrust or skepticism towards outgroups, and conspiratorial thinking. To measure support for strongman rule we asked respondents to what extent they agreed with the following statement: “having a strong and honest leader who does not have to bother with Congress or elections be a good way of governing the United States”. This way of measuring support for strongman rule is consistent with other studies (see, for example, Piazza 2024).⁹ Preference for strongman rule is relatively

⁹ Prior research suggests that support for a strong executive may be influenced by which party controls the government (Littvay, McCoy, and Simonovits 2024). However, since our survey was fielded during a Democratic administration, we view our use of this measure as a conservative test—likely dampening, rather than inflating, expressions of support for strongman rule among right-leaning respondents.

evenly distributed across categories in the sample. Approximately 31.4 percent of subjects indicated that they strongly disagreed with this sort of rule for the United States while around 24.2 somewhat disagreed. Around 28.0 percent somewhat agreed while 16.3 percent strongly agreed.

To measure perceived outgroup threat, we asked respondents the extent to which they agreed with the following statements: (1) “discrimination against other racial, religious or other minority groups is a problem today”, (2) “members of racial, religious or other minority groups are too demanding in their push for equal rights”, and (3) “there is too much concern for the rights of minority groups nowadays”. The first item was then reverse-coded so that higher values across all items indicate greater perceived threat. We combine responses to these three questions into an additive index, ranging from 2 to 13, where higher scores indicate a higher level of perceived threat, and then divide the measure by three to create an average score across all responses. The median score for our respondents is 6, on the 2 to 13 scale.

To measure conspiratorial thinking, we surveyed respondents on the extent to which they agreed with a set of four statements devised and validated in previous studies (Uscinski et al. 2016; Enders et al. 2020; Uscinski et al. 2022; Enders et al. 2023). We combine responses to these four questions into an additive index, ranging from 4 to 20, where higher scores indicate a higher aptitude for conspiratorial thinking. The median score for our respondents is 15.

Controls

In the models we control for respondents’ age, gender, marital status, parental status, race and ethnicity, education level, income level, employment status, partisan affiliation, political conservatism, religious affiliation, news consumption habits, perceived personal threat from

terrorism, residential context (e.g., urban, or rural), the U.S. region where they reside (e.g., Northeast, Midwest, South, or West), and survey completion time (in seconds).

In the sample, the median age for respondents was 45 and around 47.2 percent were male. Approximately 41.7 percent were married and 56.8 percent reported having children. In terms of race, around 68.3 percent of respondents identified as white, non-Hispanic, 10.4 percent as black, non-Hispanic, 12.2 percent as Hispanic or Latino, 4.6 percent as Asian or Pacific Islander. Approximately 11.0 percent identified as another race or ethnicity or of mixed race. The median respondent reported having completed some college but did not obtain a degree. The median household income of subjects was between U.S. \$40,000 and \$44,999 annually. Around 11.3 percent of respondents reported being unemployed and seeking work. Around 24.8 percent of subjects stated that they lived in a rural area.

Around 43.1 percent identified as Democrats, 35.1 percent as Republicans, and 21.7 percent as Independents. 63.7 percent of respondents identified as Christians (of multiple denominations) while around 29.6 percent stated that they were “born again.” The median respondent stated that they followed news between several times a week and daily, and around 38.1 percent stated that they obtained most of their news through social media.

In terms of perceived personal threat from terrorism, around 56.4 percent of subjects stated that thought that it was somewhat or very likely that they themselves or someone that they knew would be hurt or killed in a terrorist attack sometime in their lifetimes, indicating that a majority of respondents expressed perceived personal threat from terrorism. This relatively high level is likely the product of our exposing subjects to the fictitious news event depicting a terrorist attack.

Around 20.1 percent of subjects resided in the Northeast, 19.1 from the Midwest, 37.7 from the South, and 23.1 from the West. Finally, we also include a *Duration* variable, which captures the logged time (in seconds) each respondent spent completing the survey, to account for variation in respondent engagement or attentiveness.

An outline of the survey instrument is provided in the appendix along with a table reporting descriptive statistics for all variables used in the analysis.

Estimation

We test our primary hypotheses, which assert that individuals with populist attitudes are more likely to endorse more muscular international counterterrorism policies and more security-focused domestic counterterrorism measures, using ordinary least squares estimations (OLS). To investigate the other hypotheses regarding how support for strongman rule, perceived outgroup threat, and conspiratorial thinking mediates these relationships, we rely on structural equation models (SEM) with bootstrapped replications.

Results

Our analysis provides strong evidence that populist attitudes shape counterterrorism preferences. Before examining the mediating roles of support for strongman rule, perceived outgroup threat, and conspiratorial thinking, we first present the baseline findings, as illustrated in Figures 3 and 4. The corresponding regression tables are available in the appendix.

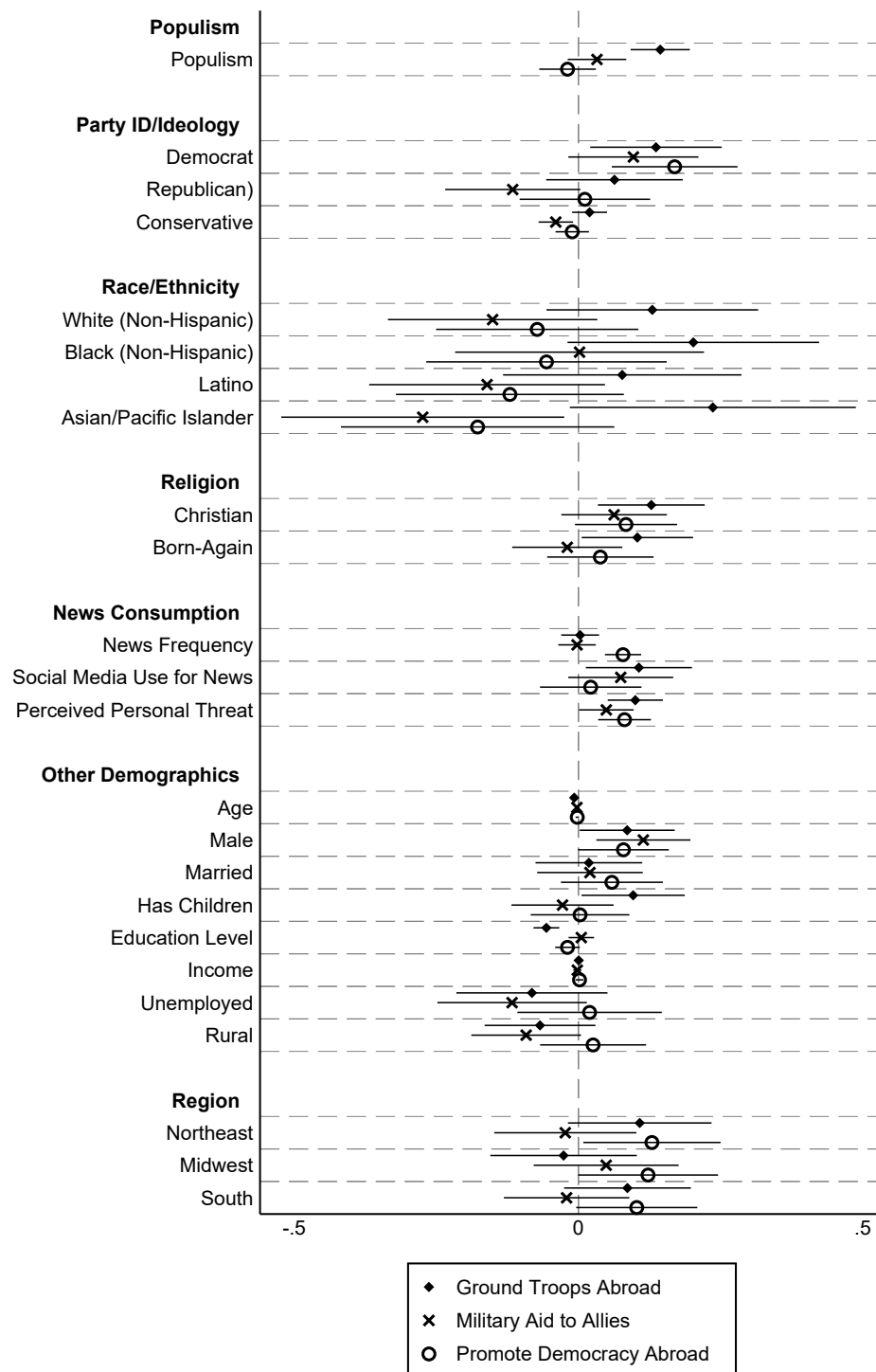
Figure 3 displays coefficient plot results from the three foreign counterterrorism policy models, each assessing support for a different international counterterrorism strategy.¹⁰ The first

¹⁰ Predicted probability graphs for all models are presented in the appendix.

model—*Ground Troops Abroad*—yields evidence that individuals with higher populism scores are significantly more likely to support deploying U.S. troops abroad to combat terrorism. This aligns with prior research suggesting that populists favor militarized, unilateral foreign policy approaches (Isernia et al. 2024). However, the second and third models—*Military Aid/Intel to Allies* and *Promote Democracy Abroad*—yield null results, suggesting that populist attitudes do not significantly influence support for multilateral cooperation or liberal counterterrorism strategies. Collectively, these findings indicate that while populists may not explicitly reject multilateral or liberal policies, their preferences strongly favor unilateral and militaristic counterterrorism responses. Notably, the *Ground Troops Abroad* model suggests that populist sentiment has a greater substantive effect on support for troop deployment than party identification or ideological orientation. Figure 3 further visualizes the predicted effect of populist sentiment on support for troop deployment, comporting with an 28.9% increase in support between individuals with the lowest and highest levels of populist attitudes.¹¹

¹¹ Note, we present graphs of postestimation marginal effects of the impact of populism on the six dependent variables of the study in the appendix.

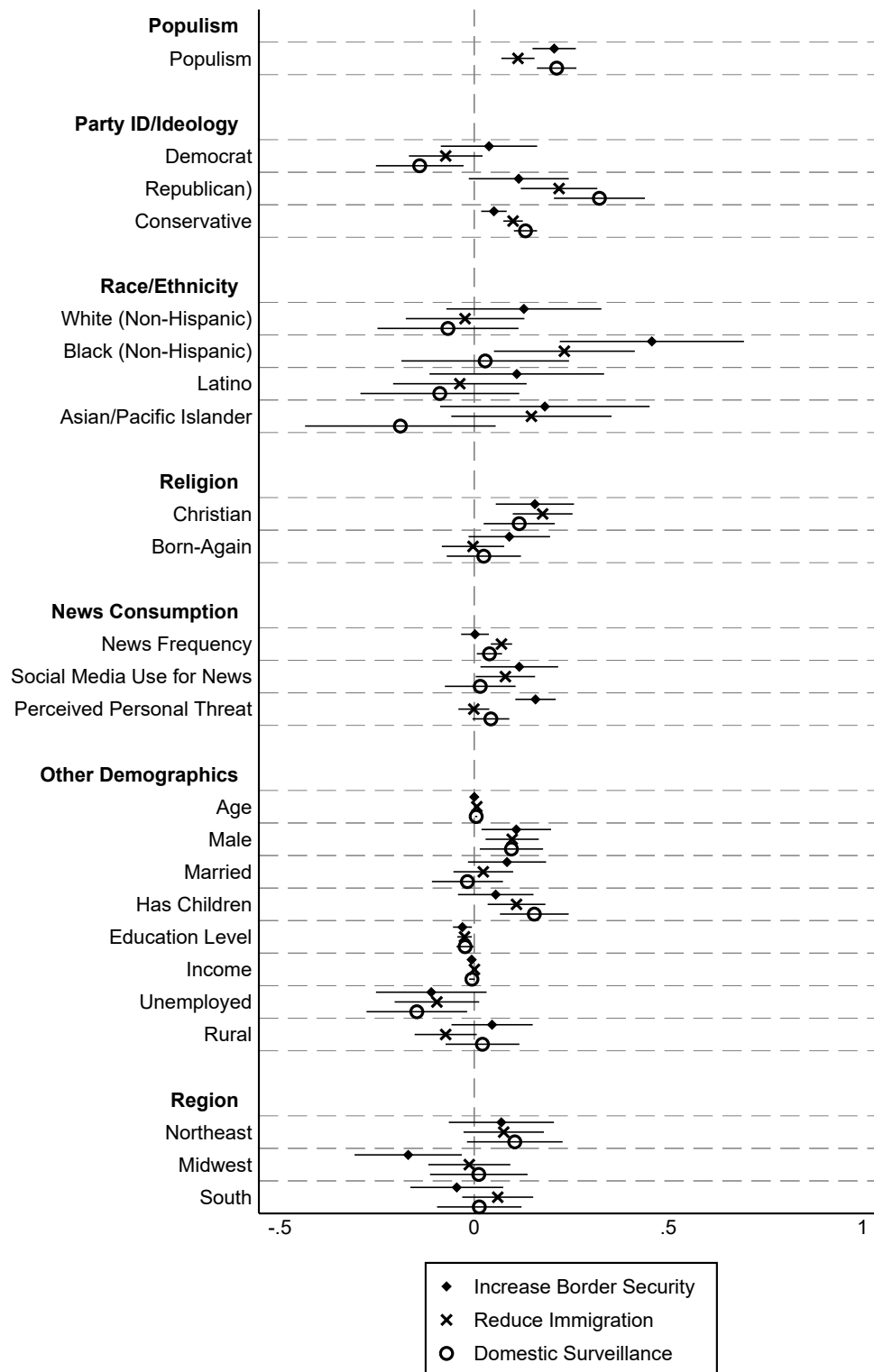
Figure 3. Coefficient Plots, Foreign CT Policy



95% Confidence Intervals
Non-Standardized Coefficients

Turning to domestic counterterrorism policies, Figure 4 presents coefficient plots for models assessing the relationship between populism and support for increasing border security, reducing immigration, and expanding government authority to surveil/detain/arrest individuals perceived as potential domestic security threats. Across all three models, populist attitudes are positive, strong and significant predictors of support for more restrictive domestic counterterrorism measures. These results align with prior studies linking populism to skepticism toward outgroups (Jacobs and van Spanje 2021; Bonikowski and Zhang 2023; Magalhães and Costa-Lopes 2023). Strikingly, our models indicate that populist sentiment have a larger substantive effect on support for these measures than either Republican Party affiliation or general ideological conservatism.

Figure 4. Coefficient Plots, Domestic CT Policy



95% Confidence Intervals
Non-Standardized Coefficients

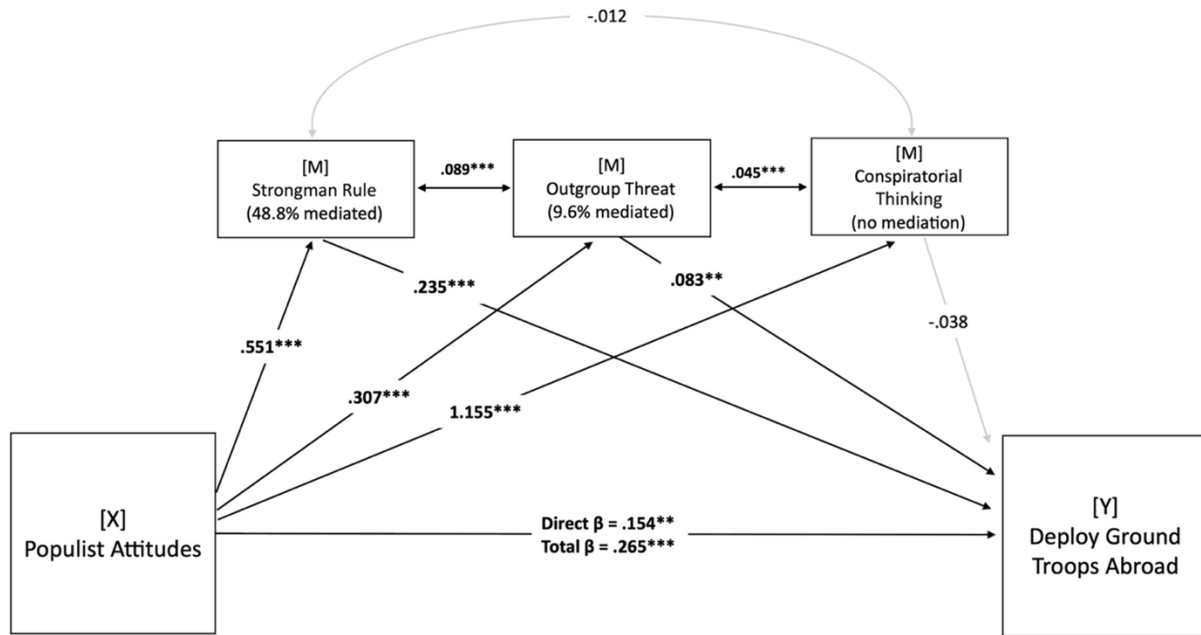
Mediation Analysis

To test for mediation, we conducted structural equation modeling (SEM) with bootstrapped replications using the `sem` package in STATA. The results, summarized in Figures 5–8, provide strong evidence for our hypotheses, suggesting populist attitudes work through other factors to shape individuals responses to terrorist attacks.¹²

Figure 5 evaluates the effects of our three mediators on support for deploying ground troops abroad. Populism is a strong positive predictor of support for strongman rule, which, in turn, is associated with support for foreign troop deployments (H1). This finding aligns with prior research linking authoritarian political attitudes to muscular foreign policy preferences (Rathbun et al. 2016; Mutz and Kim 2017; Albuyeh and Paradis 2018). Similarly, perceptions of outgroup threat significantly mediate the relationship between populism and support for troop deployments (H3), echoing studies associating ethnocentrism with unilateral militarism (Kam and Kinder 2007; Kertzer et al. 2014; Rathbun et al. 2016). However, while populism strongly correlates with conspiratorial beliefs, conspiratorial thinking does not significantly predict support for militarized counterterrorism policies. Support for strongman rule mediates approximately 48.8 percent of the effect of populism on support for deploying ground troops abroad to counter terrorist threats. Perceived outgroup threat mediates a much smaller percent: 9.6 percent.

¹² Note that mediation requires the independent variable to be significantly associated with the dependent variable (see Baron and Kenny 1986). Because we did not find populism to significantly predict provision of military aid and intelligence to allies and democracy promotion in our first set of analyses, we therefore cannot conduct mediation tests on them.

Figure 5. Mediation, Populist Attitudes, Support for Strongman Rule, Perceived Outgroup Threat, Conspiratorial Thinking and Deploying Ground Troops Abroad to Address Terrorist Threats



Structural Equation Modeling (SEM)

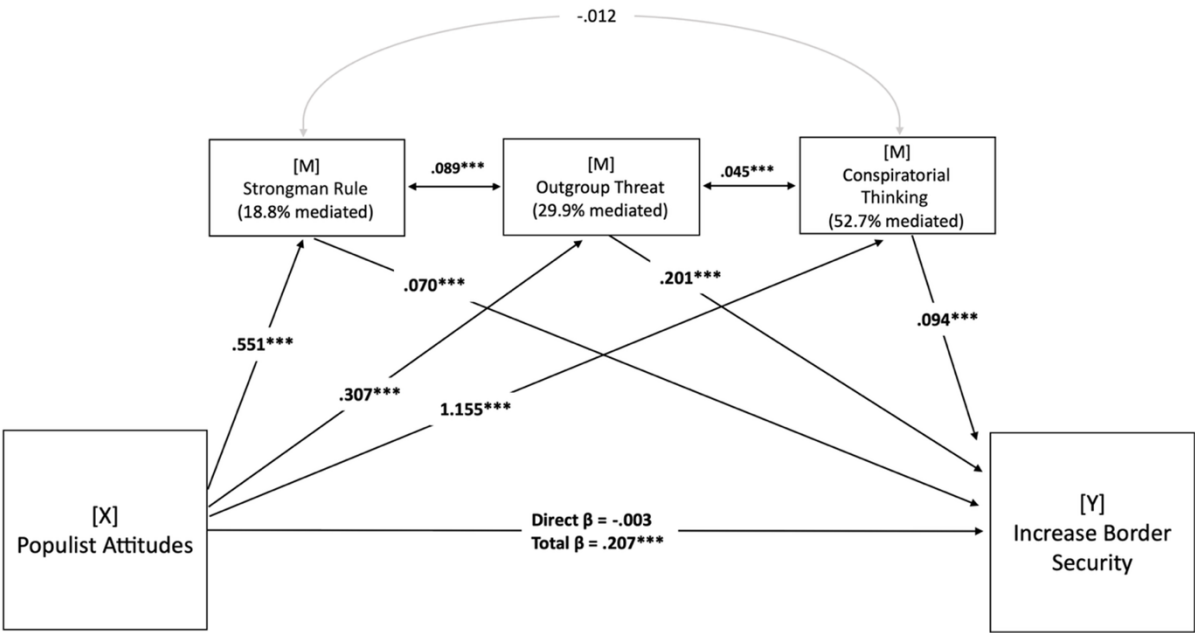
*** $p \leq .000$ ** $p \leq .01$ * $p \leq .1$

1,000 bootstrapped iterations

Controls: age, gender, marital status, children, race, education level, income level, rural residence, partisan affiliation, political ideology, religious affiliation, religious attitudes, news consumption, social media usage, fear of being a victim of terrorism, region of residence in U.S., duration of survey (log).

Figures 6–8 assess how our three mediators shape the relationship between populist attitudes and support for border security, immigration restrictions, and domestic surveillance/arrests. Across all models, support for strongman rule, outgroup threat, and conspiratorial beliefs significantly predict support for these domestic security measures (with the exception of conspiratorial thinking not predicting support for domestic surveillance).

Figure 6. Mediation, Populist Attitudes, Support for Strongman Rule, Perceived Outgroup Threat, Conspiratorial Thinking and Increasing Border Security to Address Terrorist Threats



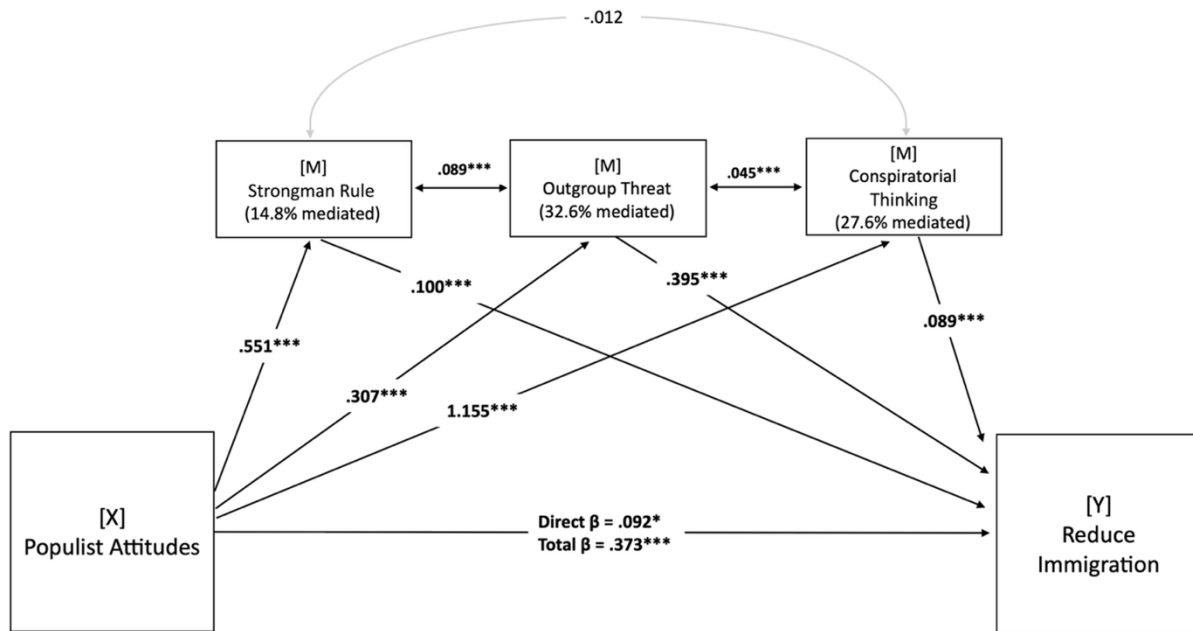
Structural Equation Modeling (SEM)

*** $p \leq .000$ ** $p \leq .01$ * $p \leq .1$

1,000 bootstrapped iterations

Controls: age, gender, marital status, children, race, education level, income level, rural residence, partisan affiliation, political ideology, religious affiliation, religious attitudes, news consumption, social media usage, fear of being a victim of terrorism, region of residence in U.S., duration of survey (log).

Figure 7. Mediation, Populist Attitudes, Support for Strongman Rule, Perceived Outgroup Threat, Conspiratorial Thinking and Reducing Immigration to Address Terrorist Threats



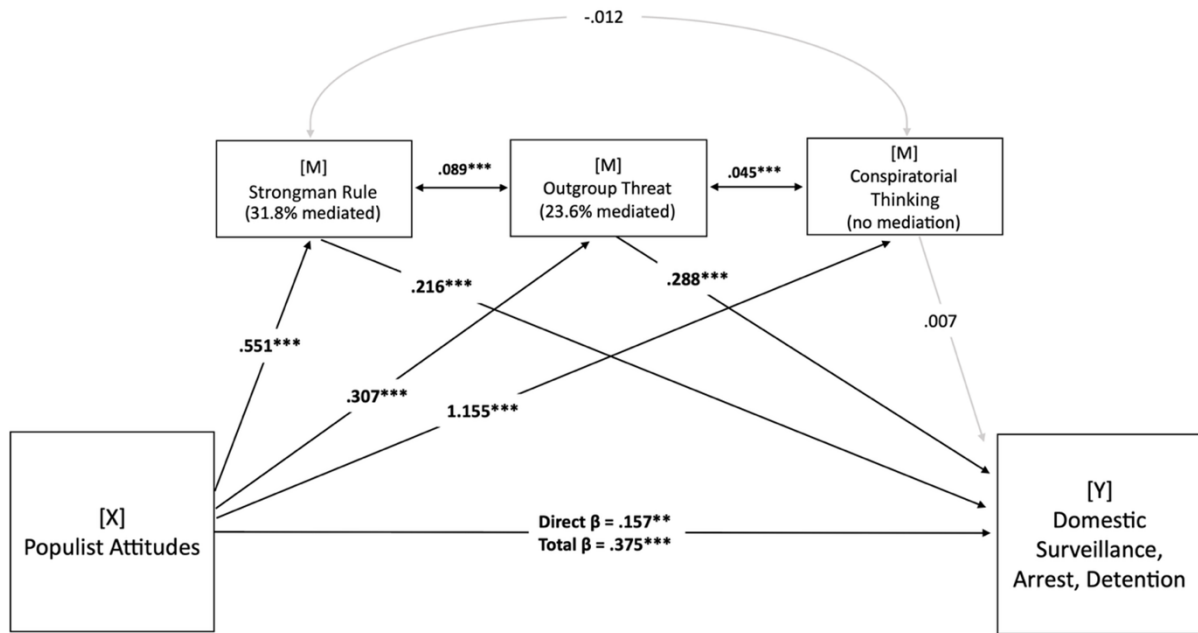
Structural Equation Modeling (SEM)

*** $p \leq .000$ ** $p \leq .01$ * $p \leq .1$

1,000 bootstrapped iterations

Controls: age, gender, marital status, children, race, education level, income level, rural residence, partisan affiliation, political ideology, religious affiliation, religious attitudes, news consumption, social media usage, fear of being a victim of terrorism, region of residence in U.S., duration of survey (log).

Figure 8. Mediation, Populist Attitudes, Support for Strongman Rule, Perceived Outgroup Threat, Conspiratorial Thinking and Domestic Surveillance, Arrest, and Detention of People from Same Communities as Terrorists to Address Terrorist Threats



Structural Equation Modeling (SEM)

*** $p \leq .000$ ** $p \leq .01$ * $p \leq .1$

1,000 bootstrapped iterations

Controls: age, gender, marital status, children, race, education level, income level, rural residence, partisan affiliation, political ideology, religious affiliation, religious attitudes, news consumption, social media usage, fear of being a victim of terrorism, region of residence in U.S., duration of survey (log).

First, support for strongman rule mediates the link between populist sentiment and support for increasing border security (Figure 6), reducing immigration (Figure 7), and expanding surveillance/arrests of domestic populations perceived as terrorist sympathizers (Figure 8) (H2). This finding aligns with prior research showing that individuals with populist views tend to prioritize security over institutional checks on executive power, or civil liberties (Piazza 2023; Salvati et al. 2022). Similarly, perceived outgroup threat mediates these relationships (H4), as populists' skepticism toward outgroups is associated with increased support for expanded domestic security measures. Together, support for strongman rule and

perceived outgroup threat account for 48% of the relationship between populism and support for border security and 55% of the relationship between populism and increased domestic surveillance.

Finally, conspiratorial thinking mediates the relationship between populism and most—but not all—domestic security responses (H5). As shown in Figures 6 and 7, conspiratorial thinking significantly predicts greater support for border security and immigration restrictions, mediating approximately 53% of the relationship between populism and support for increased border security and 27.6% of the relationship between populism and support for reducing immigration. This finding is consistent with research linking populism to conspiracy beliefs (Erisen et al. 2024; Salvati et al. 2022; Uscinski et al. 2022) and conspiratorial skepticism toward outgroups (van Prooijen 2018; Papaioannou et al. 2023). However, as shown in Figure 8, conspiratorial thinking does not significantly predict support for surveillance, arrests, or detention of domestic groups perceived as terrorist sympathizers.

Our findings, thus, demonstrate that populist attitudes strongly influence counterterrorism preferences, aligning with our theoretical expectations. Populists favor unilateral, militarized responses to terrorism abroad while showing no significant support for multilateral cooperation or democracy promotion in foreign policy decisions around counterterrorism. Domestically, they are significantly more likely to endorse border security measures, immigration restrictions, and surveillance or detention of perceived domestic security threats. Mediation analysis reveals that support for strongman rule and perceptions of outgroup threat largely drive these preferences of populists.

Conclusion

This study contributes to the body of research demonstrating that populism in the United States extends beyond electoral dynamics to shape policy preferences. The findings highlight how American populist attitudes align with broader global trends in populism, emphasizing skepticism toward international cooperation and a preference for unilateral action over multilateral engagement (Ivarsflaten 2008; Mudde and Kaltwasser 2018; Berman 2021; Isernia 2024).

On the international front, the findings reveal that populist individuals in the U.S. strongly favor a militarized, unilateral approach to counterterrorism over cooperative, or multilateral strategies. Notably, populism is not significantly associated with support for military aid to allies, intelligence sharing, or democracy promotion, whereas it strongly predicts support for troop deployment abroad. This preference aligns with broader populist skepticism toward international institutions and alliances, reinforcing a worldview that prioritizes national sovereignty. Unlike European populists, who are often wary of military entanglements beyond their region and skeptical of American global leadership, American populists show strong support for foreign military interventions for counterterrorism purposes. This distinct pattern may reflect post-9/11 legacies or a broader U.S. tradition of military assertiveness. As populist sentiment grows, foreign policymakers may face increasing pressure to shift away from multilateral counterterrorism strategies in favor of go-it-alone tactics—a trend that could have significant implications for global security partnerships.

Domestically, the study finds that American populists strongly favor counterterrorism policies that emphasize border security, immigration restrictions, and heightened surveillance or detention, echoing some patterns observed among European right-wing populist electorates. The

role of support for strongman governance and outgroup threat perceptions in shaping these preferences suggests that, for individuals with populist attitudes, counterterrorism policy may be informed both by security concerns and by efforts to reinforce boundaries around national identity. While our empirical results point to a general relationship between populist attitudes and support for hardline security policies across the left-right spectrum, the mechanisms we identify such as nativism, or out-group threat, are most consistent with right-wing variants of populism. Future research could explore how left-wing populist movements articulate different conceptions of societal threat.

Future research can build on our findings in several additional ways. First, we employed mediation analyses to better understand the role of strongman views, outgroup threat, and conspiratorial thinking in shaping how populist attitudes influence counterterrorism preferences. Future research might explore a broader range of potential mechanisms, such as institutional distrust, or affective polarization. Furthermore, since mediation analysis, like all observational methods, does not establish causal identification, future research can consider experimental designs better suited to testing causal pathways.

Secondly, future work might examine how the expression of populist attitudes varies across partisan lines. Given the centrality of party identity in American politics, studying the partisan contours of populist sentiment could shed further light on the conditions under which such attitudes translate into support for specific counterterrorism policies.

Finally, researchers can explore the role of media and online information ecosystems in reinforcing or challenging populist narratives, especially given the rising influence of social media as a news source. One promising direction is to assess how emerging digital technologies, including algorithmic news feeds and micro-targeted political messaging on social media, further

reinforce populist narratives. Recent research indicates that individuals' demand for content moderation of incivility, intolerance, and violent threats on social media is rather low (Pradel et al. 2024), that increasing partisan polarization fuels the spread of “fake news” on social media (Osmundsen et al. 2021), and that users' exposure to political posts is driven not only by partisan alignment but also by the intensity of their political engagement (Haselswerdt and Fine 2024). This suggests that highly engaged users—regardless of party identification or ideology—may be especially susceptible to digital messages that reinforce populist attitudes toward national security, as they are continually exposed to unmoderated and polarizing content.

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